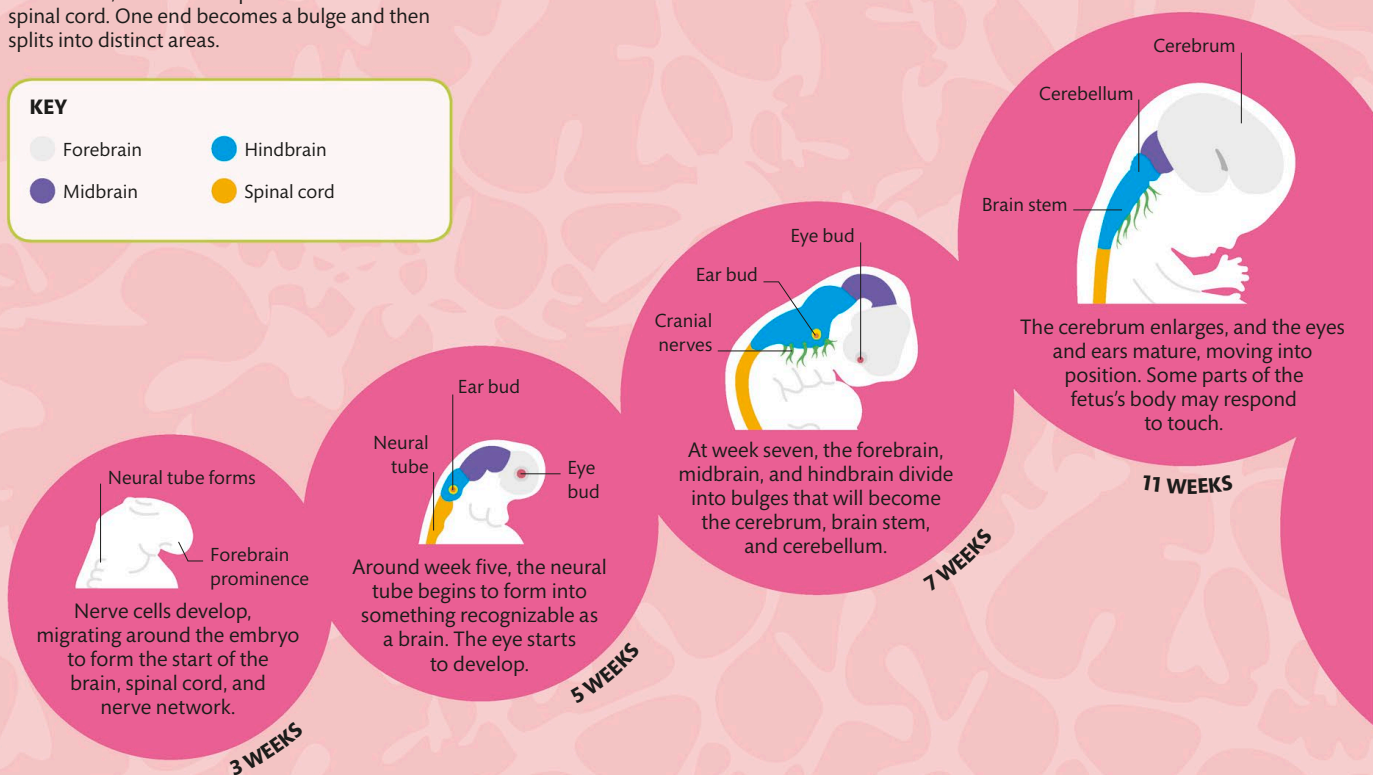


Brain development

The first nerve cells are produced just days after conception. These cells form into a plate and then curl to become a liquid-filled structure, called the neural tube, which develops into the brain and spinal cord. One end becomes a bulge and then splits into distinct areas.

KEY

- Forebrain
- Hindbrain
- Midbrain
- Spinal cord



Babies and Young Children

The human brain begins to develop after conception and changes rapidly for the first few years of life, but it takes more than 20 years for a brain to fully mature.

Before birth

An embryo's brain has a lot of development to do, going from just a few nerve cells three weeks after conception to an organ with specialized areas that is ready to start learning from birth. Genes control this process, but the environment can affect it as well. Insufficient nutrition can change brain development, and extreme stress on the mother during pregnancy can have an impact, too.

RECOGNIZING FACES

Babies prefer looking at face-like images and learn about faces rapidly. An area of the cortex called the face recognition area (see p.68) becomes specialized in identifying faces. Chess champions also use this area to recognize board layouts, suggesting that the most important patterns in a person's life are decoded there.



FACELIKE



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